envelope farther with *Bastar*, which covers events between 2007 and 2013 and also stars Adah Sharma. "So far, in Indian cinema Naxals were shown as Robin Hoods, doing good for the poor and Adivasis. But the reality is very different," says Shah. "*Bastar* will be far more hard-hitting. There will be uncomfortable truths without mincing words and political correctness. Nothing is shown just for effect. Let people decide on whether we are lying or telling the truth."

It remains to be seen whether Shah's upcoming film comes under the scanner of the Supreme Court like *The Kerala Story* did, after which the producers had to add a disclaimer that the film is a fictionalised account of events and that there's no authentic data to corroborate its claims that 32,000 women were forced to convert to Islam. Shah is one of the few film personalities to show where his own political allegiance lies. He says the current government "has been pretty liberal to whomsoever with whatever film they wanted to make", unlike previous administrations. "People tell me right now there's so much optimism and enthusiasm.... This is right time to make happy cinema. But I am going to tell stories that make you uncomfortable," he says. It should be noted that *The Kerala Story* hardly took a line that would miff the Centre. Instead, Sen and Shah targeted the Communists for ignoring the cases of Muslim men wooing Hindu women and later indoctrinating them into ISIS.

Films depicting the inconvenient, dark realities inhabited by the nation have always had an audience. The 1970s and '80s parallel movement saw the likes of Shyam Benegal, Ketan Mehta, Gulzar and Govind Nihalani, among others, hold up a mirror to the grim truths of society. However, the current crop of filmmakers takes a less nuanced, more provocative approach to lure viewers in. It entails mocking a few politicians—with names changed but the resemblance soundly established—in order to draw laughs. The more controversial the subject the more likely it is to resonate. The more visceral the fear on screen, the more discussion it generates. "Such films tend to evoke emotions like disgust, sadness, anger and fear, which are very different from positive emotions like joy, trust and anticipation, which most mainstream films evoke," says Shailesh Kapoor of Ormax Media, a leading agency which tracks entertainment industry trends, box office data and media consumption patterns. Ormax's data suggests that the audience profile for films like *The Kerala Story* doesn't fit that of regular watchers of Bollywood films. "Many people who rarely or never visit theatres went to watch the film only because of peer conversations," he notes. "The audience don't need to be convinced while watching that this happened. It's the validation of an idea which you have already believed to be true. It doesn't matter much if it is factually correct."



Nine months after its theatrical release in May '23, ZEE5 said *The Kerala Story* crossed 150 million watch minutes in its launch weekend

NEW RULES OF SHOOTING

Trade pundit Himesh Mankad cautions that jumping on the 'controversial film' bandwagon is not a "sureshot formula" to plan a successful film. "It only sells till the time it is unique. Once there's an overdose of anything, it doesn't work," he says. It's perhaps why the big studios and stars have thus far resisted making the overtly propaganda film. "Once bigger names are involved, the bigger the controversy becomes," he says. "The politics is risky and you never can say what can backfire when." Case in point being *Fighter*, which, despite celebrating the heroic exploits of an Indian Air Force fighter pilot—played by Hrithik Roshan, no less—in the Balakot airstrike and making a punching bag out of Pakistan, failed to breach the Rs 300 crore mark.

The producers know they need not be dependent on a superstar or an accomplished director to set the project rolling or get eyeballs. Mounted on budgets under Rs 50 crore, films like *The Kashmir Files* and *The Kerala Story* have seen profits soar. They have also reinvented the rules of marketing, with word-of-mouth publicity on social media platforms like Facebook, Whatsapp and X.

Jambhale, only 30, hopes that *Article 370* encourages more filmmakers to broach topics that many presume don't lend themselves to cinematic treatment. "These stories need to be told. As opposed to a reporter, we filmmakers can express opinions," he says. "You may differ with my opinion but, more than politics, it is generating awareness." Those opinions, of course, need to account for factual accuracy as much as entertainment. For the time being, the audience is hooked to the formula. Political controversy sells, after all. ■